



# Uruguay



Situated in southeastern South America, Uruguay returned to civilian government in 1985, after 12 years of military rule. Most land is used for farming: Uruguay is a major wool exporter.



## GEOGRAPHY

Low, rolling grasslands cover 80% of the country. Narrow coastal plain. Alluvial floodplain in southwest. Five rivers flow westward and drain into the Uruguay River.



## CLIMATE

Temperate throughout the country. Warm summers, mild winters, and moderate rainfall.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Uruguayans are largely second- or third-generation Italians or Spaniards. Wealth derived from cattle ranching enabled the country to establish the first welfare state in South America. Despite economic decline since the 1950s, a large, if less prosperous, middle class remains. Though a Roman Catholic country, Uruguay is liberal in its attitude to religion and all forms are tolerated.



## THE ECONOMY

Exports wool, meat, hides, rice, wood, soy. Rebounded from 1999–2002 economic crisis. Mineral potential.



**INSIGHT:** *Uruguay's rich pastures are ideal for raising livestock; animal products bring in over 40% of export earnings*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Eastern Republic of Uruguay

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1828

**CAPITAL:** Montevideo

**POPULATION:** 3.36 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 68,039 sq. miles  
(176,220 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 50 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Spanish\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 66%, other 30%, Jewish 2%, Protestant 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** White 90%, Mestizo 6%, Black 4%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Urug. peso = 100 centésimos